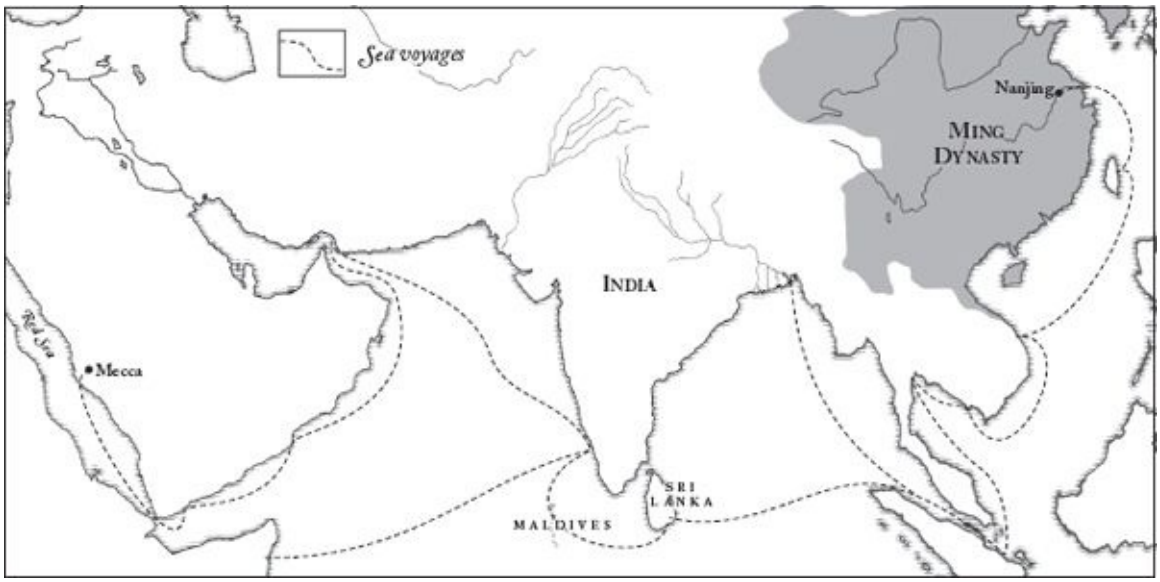
landscapes, the food and drink of a dozen different countries. But these were not voyages of discovery. Cheng Ho's "star-guided rafts" were loaded with armed Ming soldiers; his mission was to collect tribute and submission from every king he encountered. He was tasked with conquest, not diplomacy: "Upon arriving at foreign cities, capture those barbarian kings who resist civilization and are disrespectful," he summed up his instructions, in his own words. "Exterminate those bandit soldiers that indulge in violence and plunder. The ocean routes will be safe thanks to this." He had the hardware to back up his intentions: hundreds and hundreds of nine-masted ships, thousands of deck-mounted bronze cannon, tens of thousands of Ming marines packed aboard. [4]

While Cheng Ho led his fleets farther and farther abroad, the Emperor Yongle personally conducted five different campaigns against the Oirats and the Northern Yuan. He fought in the north; Cheng Ho sailed to the west; and yet another Ming army was dispatched to the south.



90.1. The Sea Voyages of the Yongle Emperor

This south-pointing army, five hundred thousand strong, was ostensibly sent to restore the Tran dynasty to the throne of the Dai Viet, and to remove the usurping Ho ruler. This was a good and moral motivation, a "righteous war" according to Confucian doctrines, carried out to restore the proper order. "When the criminal [Ho] is captured, we will select a virtuous offspring of the Tran family as king," Yongle decreed. "We will help him rule the place, and then withdraw our forces." [5]

It was a good front, but once the Ming soldiers had destroyed the Ho